ThinkRail

Step-by-step guide: install and start using it

Open-source agentic IDE from JetBrains · Apache-2.0 · by @techie.addy

> **Kya hai ThinkRail?** A desktop and browser IDE built around the **pi** coding agent. Every task gets its own git-worktree workspace, and **SPEC.md** files give the agent long-term knowledge of your project. This guide covers install, first run, and the main features.

Before you start

- **git** must be on your PATH. The CLI needs it, and projects are git repos.
- **Model access:** sign in with JetBrains AI inside the app, or connect your own provider through pi's auth. ThinkRail has no accounts of its own.
- **GitHub CLI (gh), for PR workflows only:** shipping a pull request runs through your own `gh`.

1 Install ThinkRail

Pick one option. The command line is the quickest.

OPTION A · COMMAND LINE (macOS, Linux, or Windows under Git Bash)

```
curl -fsSL https://raw.githubusercontent.com/JetBrains/thinkrail/main/install.sh | bash
```

The installer downloads the binary, verifies its SHA-256 checksum, and puts `thinkrail` on your PATH.

OPTION B · WINDOWS (cmd or PowerShell)

```
powershell -c "irm https://raw.githubusercontent.com/JetBrains/thinkrail/main/install.ps1 | iex"
```

OPTION C · DESKTOP APP

Download the `thinkrail-desktop-*` file for your system from the repo's Releases page:

- **macOS:** Apple Silicon only. Open the DMG. There is no Intel desktop build.
- **Windows x64:** extract the complete setup ZIP, then run the setup executable in place, next to its files.
- **Linux x64 / ARM64:** extract the setup tarball and run `installer`. You need Ubuntu 24.04 or newer (glibc 2.38+).

LINUX DESKTOP LIBRARIES

```
sudo apt install libgtk-3-0 libwebkit2gtk-4.1-0 libayatana-appindicator3-1 librsvg2-2
```

2 Open it with your project

Run `thinkrail` and pass a git repo path to open it as a project. The CLI opens the same app in your browser.

```
thinkrail ~/code/my-repo
thinkrail --help       # all flags
thinkrail --version    # installed build
```

3 Connect a model

Sign in with **JetBrains AI** from the app, or connect your own provider through pi's auth. Each chat shows its own model and cost readout.

4 Work in isolated workspaces

Open any git repo as a project, then create a workspace for each task. A workspace is a **git worktree** with its own branch and working directory, so your main checkout stays untouched.

- Run several pi chats in one workspace, each with its own model. You can steer a running turn, queue follow-ups, and delegate to subagents.
- Agents can work in parallel. When one branch is good, merge it and delete the rest.
- Finished workspaces move to a shelf automatically.

5 Let SPEC.md remember your project

`SPEC.md` files form a graph next to your code. The agent reads them and keeps them updated through its `spec_*` tools, so it gets better as your project grows. The README calls these **living specs**.

6 Add Skills and MCP servers

- **Agent Skills:** your existing skills are read in place. Bundled workflows cover project setup, design brainstorming, and shipping a pull request.
- **MCP servers:** connect them from your pi `mcp.json` or add them in Settings. ThinkRail asks before any call that is not marked read-only.

7 Ship with the GitHub PR flow

The top bar tracks your branch against `origin` and its pull request. From there you can:

- Publish or push the branch and open a PR.
- See CI checks and the review decision once the PR is open.
- Mark it ready, merge it, or delete the remote branch.
- Hand failing checks to the agent to fix.

8 Update, uninstall, privacy

```
thinkrail update                      # re-runs the installer for your channel
thinkrail uninstall                   # removes the binary, PATH entry, install data
thinkrail uninstall --remove-data -y  # also delete ~/.thinkrail, no prompts
thinkrail --no-analytics              # turn analytics off for one run
```

- **Desktop app:** updates are checked in the background. Apply them from **Settings > Updates** with **Install & Restart**.
- **Nightly builds:** the installer accepts `-- --channel nightly` after `bash -s`. On Windows, use the `THINKRAIL_CHANNEL` environment variable.

Links: Website thinkrail.ai · Repo github.com/JetBrains/thinkrail · Discord thinkrail.ai/discord

Based on the project README on 1 Nov 2026. ThinkRail is a JetBrains incubator project and changes quickly, so check the README if a command or option has changed.